



The Gospel of Matthew

Jesus Christ, King of the Kingdom — a simplified
chapter-by-chapter study

Come unto Me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden

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Introduction

Many people love the Lord Christ with all their hearts, yet they have never read a whole Gospel from beginning to end in their lives. They open the Gospel now and then, read a verse here and a verse there, then close it. This book was born for them: a calm, simple journey through the Gospel of Matthew, chapter by chapter, with no theological complications and no difficult language. Each chapter of this book takes you on a tour inside one chapter — or a group of chapters — of the Gospel: what happened? Why was it written? And what does it mean for my life today?

Did you know that the Gospel of Matthew is the first book of the New Testament, and that it was written especially for the Jews, to prove to them that Jesus of Nazareth is the Messiah promised in the Old Testament — the King they had awaited for generations? That is why this Gospel is full of fulfilled prophecies, and why it opens with a key phrase that sums up everything: “The book of the generation of Jesus Christ, the son of David, the son of Abraham” (Matt 1:1). Jesus is the Son of David — the promised King — and the Son of Abraham — the one in whom all the nations will be blessed. And as you read, you will notice that Matthew organizes Christ's teachings into five great discourses, like a new five books of Moses, and that the phrase “the kingdom of heaven” appears here more than in any other Gospel.

How should you use this book? It is best to first read the chapter itself from the Gospel of Matthew — take your Gospel and read it slowly, even ten minutes only — then read the matching chapter of this study. Do not rush; the Gospel is not a race. Read one chapter a day, or one chapter every two days, and let the Word settle in your heart. At the end of each chapter you will find a question for meditation and a short prayer, for meditation and prayer are the two wings of spiritual reading in our Coptic Orthodox tradition.

And to read this Gospel with deeper understanding, notice its beautiful structure: Matthew arranged Christ's life and teachings around five great discourses — the Sermon on the Mount, the sending of the disciples, the parables of the kingdom, the discourse on the Church, and the eschatological discourse — closing each one with the phrase: “And it came to pass, when

Jesus had ended these sayings.” As though presenting us with a new law of five books, matching the five old books of Moses. And between these discourses he narrates the deeds: the Nativity, the Baptism, the miracles, the Passion, the Resurrection. Teaching and works, words and deeds — this is how Christ was, and this is how we ought to be: we hear the Word and we do it.

This study is written for the ordinary reader: the mother at home, the young man at his university, the worker in his workshop, and everyone who wants to know Christ with a deeper personal knowledge. We have quoted commentaries only rarely here; we have tried instead to explain the text itself in today's language. And the few verses quoted are taken from the public-domain English King James Version. Let us begin this blessed journey together, and let us pray that the Lord will open our minds as He opened the minds of the two disciples of Emmaus, that we may understand the Scriptures.

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Chapter 1

Who Is Matthew? And to Whom Was This Gospel Written?

Before he was an evangelist, Matthew was a tax collector. Picture the scene: a Jewish man sitting at the tax booth on the trade road, collecting taxes from his own people for the Roman occupier — and taking extra for himself. The Jews despised tax collectors, regarding them as traitors and sinners beyond repentance; they would not sit with them nor eat with them. And into the midst of this contempt, Jesus passed by the tax booth one day, looked at Matthew sitting there, and said to him one word that changed his life forever: “Follow me.” So Matthew arose and left everything and followed Him (Matt 9:9). He did not ask about the salary he would leave behind, nor about the future — he arose at once. This is true repentance: an instant, complete break with the past.

And how beautiful it is that Matthew himself tells us the story of his calling in his Gospel — yet he tells it with astonishing humility. He calls himself by his shameful name, “Matthew the publican,” when listing the names of the twelve apostles (Matt 10:3), while the other two evangelists call him “Levi.” He does not hide his past; he makes it his testimony: look what the grace of Christ did with a wretched tax collector! He even tells how Jesus made a feast in his house right after his calling, and many tax collectors and sinners came and sat with Jesus, and the Pharisees grumbled. Jesus answered them with the golden word: “They that be whole need not a physician, but they that are sick... for I am not come to call the righteous, but sinners to repentance” (Matt 9:12-13). Matthew is living proof that no one is too far from the mercy of Christ, whatever his past.

To whom did Matthew write his Gospel? He wrote it chiefly for the Jews, and this explains everything in this Gospel. A Jew knew the Old Testament and had memorized the prophecies about the coming Messiah, so Matthew came to say to him: the One you have awaited for generations has come — and He is Jesus of Nazareth. That is why the Gospel is full of a phrase repeated like a melody:

“that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the prophet” — you find it in the Nativity, in the flight into Egypt, in the entry into Jerusalem, in the Cross itself. Matthew places beside every event in Christ's life the prophecy that preceded it by hundreds of years, as though building a bridge from the Old Testament to the New, saying to his Jewish reader: do not fear — your old faith was not abolished but fulfilled and completed.

And what is the Gospel's central message? It is “the kingdom of heaven.” This phrase appears in the Gospel of Matthew more than thirty times, and it means God's reign and authority over hearts and lives. Matthew presents Christ as King: His genealogy is royal, from David; the Magi worshipped Him as King; He entered Jerusalem as King; and He died on the Cross with the inscription above Him, “This is Jesus the King of the Jews.” But His kingdom is not of this world; it is a kingdom of righteousness, peace, and joy, entered by the humble, the repentant, and the children. That is why you will find in this Gospel five great discourses of Christ — the Sermon on the Mount, the mission of the disciples, the parables of the kingdom, the discourse on the Church, and the eschatological discourse — as though a new constitution of the Kingdom.

The Church placed the Gospel of Matthew first among the books of the New Testament, because it is the natural bridge between the Testaments: it begins where the Old Testament ended — with promises and prophecies — and shows their fulfillment in Christ. That is why the Gospel of Matthew is read so often in the liturgical readings throughout the Coptic year, and why the Church celebrates the feast of Saint Matthew the Evangelist on the 12th of Baba. And as you read this Gospel, remember its writer: a wretched tax collector who became a great evangelist. If God could use Matthew, He can use you too, whatever your past.

Reflect: Matthew left the tax booth in a single moment. What is the “tax booth” in your life? What is the thing you know Christ is calling you to leave, yet you are still sitting on? It may be an evil habit, a wrong relationship, or a love of money that blinds you. Remember that Christ did not wait for Matthew to become good first and then call him — He called him at the very height of his sin. And He is calling you today, just as you are. Arise and follow Him, and you will discover, as Matthew discovered, that what you leave for Christ's sake

cannot be compared with what you receive from Him. Pray: Lord Jesus, as You called Matthew the tax collector and he followed You, call me too. Grant me the courage to leave, and the joy of following. Amen.

Chapter 2

The Genealogy and the Wondrous Nativity

Matthew opens his Gospel with what may seem boring to the modern reader: a long list of names — “Abraham begat Isaac; and Isaac begat Jacob...” But the Jewish reader understood at once that this list is a King's birth certificate. For the prophecies said the Messiah would be the “Son of David,” that is, of the seed of King David — so Matthew came to prove, with documents, that Jesus is indeed of the tribe of Judah and of the house of David. And the first verse sums up the whole Gospel: “The book of the generation of Jesus Christ, the son of David, the son of Abraham” (Matt 1:1). Son of David: He is the promised King. Son of Abraham: He is the one in whom all the families of the earth will be blessed — meaning salvation is for Jews and Gentiles together.

Notice Matthew's wisdom in arranging the genealogy: three sections, each fourteen generations — from Abraham to David (the age of the patriarchs), from David to the captivity (the age of the kings), and from the captivity to Christ (the age of waiting). As though saying: the whole history of God's people was moving toward this moment, toward the birth of Jesus. And even the Babylonian captivity — the darkest period of their history — did not break the chain of promises; it entered into God's reckoning. How beautiful this truth is for our lives: God does not lose our wasted generations, and He is able to bring out of our broken history a complete plan of salvation.

And in this list there is a wonderful theological surprise: Matthew names four women in the genealogy of Christ — most unusual in Jewish genealogies. Tamar, Rahab, Ruth, and the wife of Uriah (Bathsheba). Three of them were Gentiles (non-Jews), and some had painful or sinful pasts. Why does Matthew name them in the genealogy of the holy King? To declare, from the very first page, that God's grace embraces sinners, Gentiles, and outcasts — and that Christ came to save these very people. He of whom you will read that He is “a friend of publicans and sinners” began His story with women like these in His family line. It is good news for everyone who thinks his past keeps him from drawing near to God.

Then Matthew moves to the wondrous Nativity itself. Mary was betrothed to Joseph, and before they came together she was found with child of the Holy Spirit. Imagine Joseph's shock: the betrothed he loved and trusted was with child — and not by him! He faced two cruel choices: to expose her publicly and have her condemned, or to divorce her quietly. And here the Gospel describes him with the most beautiful words: “Then Joseph her husband, being a just man” (Matt 1:19). His righteousness showed in his mercy: he chose to put her away quietly, so as not to shame her. True righteousness is not harsh judgment but a merciful heart. And while he was thinking about this, the angel of the Lord appeared to him in a dream and said: “Fear not to take unto thee Mary thy wife: for that which is conceived in her is of the Holy Ghost.” So Joseph obeyed at once, took Mary, and named the newborn “Jesus” — that is, “God saves” — “for he shall save his people from their sins.”

And consider with me Joseph's obedience: the angel appeared to him four times in dreams — to take Mary, to flee to Egypt, to return from Egypt, and to dwell in Nazareth — and each time “he arose and did as the angel of the Lord had bidden him,” at once, with no delay and no argument. That is why the Church honors him as the patron of silent obedience: a man of whom not one word is recorded in the Gospel, yet whose deeds spoke louder than sermons. Immediate, complete obedience is the mark of true righteousness. And when God guides you — in a dream, in prayer, or through a word of Scripture — do not argue: arise and do as Joseph did.

And Matthew adds that all this was done “that it might be fulfilled which was spoken of the Lord by the prophet, saying, Behold, a virgin shall be with child, and shall bring forth a son, and they shall call his name Emmanuel, which being interpreted is, God with us” (Matt 1:22-23). Emmanuel — God with us. This is the sum of the Nativity: God did not remain far away in His heaven; He came and dwelt among us, shared our flesh and blood, wept with those who weep and hungered with the hungry. Christmas is not merely the memory of a child in a manger; it is the announcement that God is with you — in your home, in your illness, in your loneliness. Reflect: Joseph obeyed the dream at once, without argument. Do you obey God's voice when He speaks to you, or do you argue and delay? Pray: O Emmanuel, O God who became with us, I

thank You for never leaving me alone. Teach me Joseph's instant obedience,
and fill my heart with the joy of Your presence. Amen.

Chapter 3

The Childhood: The Magi and the Flight into Egypt

After the birth of Jesus in Bethlehem, a strange visit happened that changed everything: Magi came from the east to Jerusalem, asking: “Where is he that is born King of the Jews? for we have seen his star in the east, and are come to worship him” (Matt 2:2). The Magi were wise men and scholars of astronomy from Persia or Babylon — that is, pagans who did not know the Scriptures. But God spoke to them in the language they understood: an unusual star appeared in the sky. And so the Gospel began to proclaim, from the second chapter, that Christ is not for the Jews alone, but also “a light to lighten the Gentiles.” The Jewish shepherds worshipped Him on the first night, and the Gentile Magi worshipped Him after — and the Coptic Church celebrates this meaning in the glorious feast of the Nativity.

But the news disturbed Herod the king. He was troubled, and all Jerusalem with him. Herod was a king sick with suspicion; he killed his wife and sons out of fear for his throne — so how could he hear of one “born King of the Jews” and not tremble? He gathered the chief priests and scribes and asked them: where shall Christ be born? They answered at once from the prophecy: “in Bethlehem of Judaea,” quoting the prophet Micah. Notice the painful irony: the scribes know the prophecy letter by letter, yet they did not move a single step to see Christ — while the Magi traveled thousands of miles following a star! Knowledge without obedience does its owner no good. How many of us know many verses about Christ, yet will not walk a single step toward Him?

The Magi went to Bethlehem, and saw the star standing over where the young child was, and “they rejoiced with exceeding great joy,” and entered the house and worshipped Him and presented their gifts: gold, frankincense, and myrrh. And the Church saw a deep symbolism in these gifts: gold, because He is King; frankincense, because He is God to whom incense is offered; and myrrh, because He is man who would suffer and die — for myrrh was used in embalming the dead. In Christ's cradle, the prophecy of His Cross was already

present. Then the Magi were warned in a dream not to return to Herod, so they departed by another way. Whoever truly meets Christ never returns by his old road.

As for Herod, when he saw that he was mocked by the Magi, he was exceedingly angry and ordered the killing of all the children of Bethlehem from two years old and under — the dreadful massacre of the innocents. But God had gone ahead: the angel of the Lord appeared to Joseph in a dream and said: “Arise, and take the young child and his mother, and flee into Egypt.” So Joseph arose by night and fled with the Child and His mother to Egypt, and stayed there until Herod's death, “that it might be fulfilled which was spoken of the Lord by the prophet, saying, Out of Egypt have I called my son” (Matt 2:15). Consider the greatness of this: the Child before whom the stars bowed flees as a refugee to Egypt! Christ shared with us even the bitterness of refuge, fear, and estrangement. And He is a comfort to every refugee and wanderer: your God tasted estrangement before you.

And the visit of the Holy Family blessed the land of Egypt forever, fulfilling Isaiah's prophecy: “Blessed be Egypt my people” (Isa 19:25). The Coptic Church keeps a rich tradition about the journey's route: from Al-Farma to Tel Basta, to Al-Matariyah and Ain Shams, to Old Cairo, to Maadi, to Asyut and Deir Al-Muharraq, where the Family stayed the longest. That is why our Church celebrates every year on the 24th of Pashons (June 1st) the feast of Christ's entry into the land of Egypt. O the honor of Egypt! The country that once enslaved God's people became the refuge of the Son of God, and from it Christianity went out to the whole world. If you are Egyptian, this is a special blessing for you: Christ walked your land as a child.

After Herod's death the family returned, but Joseph was afraid to dwell in Judaea because Herod's son reigned there; being warned in a dream, he turned aside to Galilee and dwelt in a city called Nazareth, “that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by the prophets, He shall be called a Nazarene.” And so many prophecies were fulfilled in Christ's childhood: born in Bethlehem, called out of Egypt, dwelling in Nazareth. Matthew wants you to see God's hand guiding the small details — Joseph's dream, the Magi's star, even Herod's evil — to reach His purposes. Reflect: do you trust that God

guides the small details of your life as He guided Christ's childhood? Pray:
Lord, as You kept the child Jesus in His flight, keep me and my family on every
road. And make me, like the Magi, follow Your light however long the journey.
Amen.

Chapter 4

John the Baptist and the Baptism of Jesus

Thirty silent years passed in Nazareth, about which the Gospel tells us nothing — then suddenly a voice rang out in the wilderness of Judaea: “Repent ye: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand” (Matt 3:2). It was John the Baptist, of whom Isaiah prophesied: “the voice of one crying in the wilderness, Prepare ye the way of the Lord.” John was an awe-inspiring figure: his clothing of camel's hair, his food locusts and wild honey, his words fire. Jerusalem and all Judaea went out to him, and were baptized by him in the Jordan, confessing their sins. He awakened the conscience of an entire nation that had been sleeping in formal religion. Repentance — turning away from sin and changing the direction of the heart — is always the first door into the kingdom of God, in every generation.

And John was blunt with everyone, without flattery. When he saw the Pharisees and Sadducees — the great religious men — coming to his baptism, he rebuked them sharply: “O generation of vipers, who hath warned you to flee from the wrath to come? Bring forth therefore fruits meet for repentance” (Matt 3:7-8). Then he demolished their reliance on lineage: “Think not to say within yourselves, We have Abraham to our father: for I say unto you, that God is able of these stones to raise up children unto Abraham.” An eternal lesson: it does you no good to be a “child of the Church” or from a devout family if you have no personal repentance and no real fruits. God knows no favoritism or connections; “now also the axe is laid unto the root of the trees: therefore every tree which bringeth not forth good fruit is hewn down, and cast into the fire.”

Then came the astonishing moment: “Then cometh Jesus from Galilee to Jordan unto John, to be baptized of him. But John forbad him, saying, I have need to be baptized of thee, and comest thou to me?” (Matt 3:13-14). A question every reader asks: why would Jesus be baptized, being without sin — when baptism was for repentance from sins? Jesus answered: “Suffer it to be so now: for thus it becometh us to fulfil all righteousness.” And the meaning is

deep: Jesus was not baptized because He was a sinner, but because He took the place of sinners. He who “knew no sin” stood for sinful humanity, descended into the water of repentance on our behalf, to sanctify baptism itself and open its door to us. And in our Coptic Church we celebrate this event in the glorious feast of the Epiphany, when Christ descended into the Jordan and sanctified the water and those washed in it.

And as soon as Jesus came up out of the water, the heavens were opened: “he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove, and lighting upon him: and lo a voice from heaven, saying, This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased” (Matt 3:16-17). O the wonder! In a single moment the Holy Trinity appeared: the Son baptized in the water, the Holy Spirit descending upon Him in the form of a dove, and the Father witnessing to Him from heaven. That is why the Church calls this feast “Theophany” — the divine manifestation. And from that day our own baptism also became Trinitarian: we are baptized “in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost,” the Holy Spirit comes upon us, and we become beloved children of the Father. Your baptism is not a social ritual; it is a moment when heaven opened over you too, and you heard the Father's voice: you are My beloved child.

And John was a model of humility despite his greatness. Christ said of him: “Among them that are born of women there hath not risen a greater than John the Baptist” (Matt 11:11) — yet John said of himself: “I am not worthy to bear his shoes,” and when his disciples began to leave him and follow Jesus, he spoke his immortal words: “He must increase, but I must decrease” (John 3:30). This is the spirit of the true servant: to rejoice in the growth of God's work even at the expense of his own prominence. Examine yourself: do you rejoice when another is praised and your name forgotten? Whoever learns from John to decrease that Christ may increase becomes great in the kingdom of heaven.

Reflect: John said of Christ: “I indeed baptize you with water unto repentance... he shall baptize you with the Holy Ghost, and with fire” (Matt 3:11). The baptism of water washed the past, but the baptism of the Spirit gives new life and power. Do you live your baptism every day, or is it an old memory in a photo album? Repentance is not a one-time event but a way of

life: every day we return to God, and every day we hear His voice saying to us: repent, for the Kingdom is at hand. Pray: O Holy Trinity, I thank You for my baptism, which made me Your child. Renew in me, O Spirit of God, Your work every day, and make the fruits of my repentance visible in my life. Amen.

Chapter 5

The Temptation on the Mount and the Beginning of the Ministry

Immediately after the Baptism, “Then was Jesus led up of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted of the devil” (Matt 4:1). Notice: the Holy Spirit Himself led Him to the temptation! Temptation, then, is not always a sign of God's anger; it may be God's school. Jesus fasted forty days and forty nights — like Moses and Elijah before Him — and “he was afterward an hungred.” And here came the tempter. The first temptation: “If thou be the Son of God, command that these stones be made bread.” The devil always begins with doubt — “If thou be the Son of God...” — the same voice that whispers to you today: if God loves you, why are you sick? Why are you poor? And he wanted Jesus to use His divine power for personal benefit. Jesus answered from Scripture: “Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God.” The first lesson: God's Word is our weapon and our true bread, and the body is not man's master.

The second temptation was more dangerous: the devil took Him to the pinnacle of the temple and said: “If thou be the Son of God, cast thyself down: for it is written, He shall give his angels charge concerning thee.” Amazing! The devil himself quotes Scripture — but he cuts the verse out of its context to justify recklessness. How many heresies and sins today are justified by a severed verse! Jesus answered also with what is written: “Thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God.” True faith is not throwing yourself from a height and demanding that God catch you; it is trusting Him and obeying Him on the right path. Do not use God's promises as an excuse for your recklessness.

The third temptation: the devil showed Him all the kingdoms of the world and their glory and said: “All these things will I give thee, if thou wilt fall down and worship me.” This is the eternal bargain Satan offers every person: glory, money, and power — for one small bow. Many have accepted the deal: selling their conscience for a promotion, lying for a deal, leaving prayer for work. But Jesus cried out: “Get thee hence, Satan: for it is written, Thou shalt worship

the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve.” The masks fell, the devil was defeated, and “behold, angels came and ministered unto him.” Notice Jesus' only weapon in all three temptations: “It is written... it is written... it is written.” Whoever keeps God's Word in his heart cannot be defeated.

And after the temptation, the public ministry began. Jesus heard that John was cast into prison, so He departed into Galilee, left Nazareth, and dwelt in Capernaum by the seaside, “that it might be fulfilled which was spoken by Esaias the prophet, saying, The land of Zabulon, and the land of Nephthalim... The people which sat in darkness saw great light” (Matt 4:14-16). Galilee was a mixed region of Jews and Gentiles, despised by the people of Jerusalem, who called it “Galilee of the Gentiles.” But Christ chose the marginalized and the forgotten as the place where the Light would begin. His first message was the same as John's: “Repent: for the kingdom of heaven is at hand” — for repentance is always the beginning.

Then He called His first disciples: Jesus was walking by the Sea of Galilee and saw two brothers, Simon (Peter) and Andrew, casting a net into the sea, for they were fishers, and said to them: “Follow me, and I will make you fishers of men.” “And they straightway left their nets, and followed him” (Matt 4:19-20). Then James and John, the sons of Zebedee — “they immediately left the ship and their father, and followed him.” How amazing this instant response! They did not say: let us finish the season first, or bid our families farewell, or think it over. They heard the voice and arose. And Jesus “went about all Galilee, teaching in their synagogues, and preaching the gospel of the kingdom, and healing all manner of sickness and all manner of disease among the people,” and His fame spread, and great multitudes followed Him. Reflect: with what do you face your temptations — your own wisdom or God's Word? And have you ever heard Christ's voice calling you to something and said “later”? Pray: Lord, teach me to answer the tempter as You answered: it is written. And make my heart ready to leave the nets and follow You at once. Amen.

Chapter 6

The Sermon on the Mount (1): The Beatitudes, Salt of the Earth, Light of the World

Jesus saw the multitudes and went up into the mountain, and His disciples sat around Him, and “he opened his mouth, and taught them, saying” (Matt 5:2). Thus began the most famous sermon in history: the Sermon on the Mount, the constitution of the kingdom of heaven. The mountain reminds us of Mount Sinai, where God gave Moses the Law; but now the Lawgiver Himself — God incarnate — gives the law of the new Kingdom, not on tablets of stone but on hearts of flesh. And He began with the Beatitudes: nine sayings, each beginning with “Blessed” — O the happiness, O the bliss.

“Blessed are the poor in spirit: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven. Blessed are they that mourn: for they shall be comforted. Blessed are the meek: for they shall inherit the earth. Blessed are they which do hunger and thirst after righteousness: for they shall be filled. Blessed are the merciful: for they shall obtain mercy. Blessed are the pure in heart: for they shall see God. Blessed are the peacemakers: for they shall be called the children of God. Blessed are they which are persecuted for righteousness' sake: for theirs is the kingdom of heaven” (Matt 5:3-10). How astonishing! The world says: blessed are the rich, the strong, the famous. But Christ blesses the poor, the mourners, the meek, the persecuted. He turns the world's standards upside down: true happiness is not in what you own, but in what you are before God. Poor in spirit is the one who knows his spiritual poverty and his need for God — and this is the first door of the Kingdom. The one who mourns over his sins is comforted by God's forgiveness. And the meek — not the weak, but the strong who master themselves — shall inherit the earth.

Then Christ moved from the qualities of the Kingdom's children to their mission in the world, with two beautiful images: “Ye are the salt of the earth... Ye are the light of the world” (Matt 5:13-14). Salt in those days preserved food from corruption — so the true believer preserves his society from the corruption of sin by his presence, his words, and his conduct. And light

scatters darkness; the Christian does not curse the darkness but lights his candle. Notice He said “ye” — you personally, not only the priest or the servant. Then He warned: “if the salt have lost his savour, wherewith shall it be salted? it is thenceforth good for nothing, but to be cast out, and to be trodden under foot of men.” A believer without influence is a contradiction; if you are not light, you are part of the darkness.

And in the rest of the chapter Christ explained that He came not to destroy the Law but to fulfill it — then He lifted the commandments to the level of the heart: “Ye have heard that it was said by them of old time, Thou shalt not kill... But I say unto you, That whosoever is angry with his brother without a cause shall be in danger of the judgment.” Murder begins in the heart, with anger and contempt. “Ye have heard that it was said, Thou shalt not commit adultery: But I say unto you, That whosoever looketh on a woman to lust after her hath committed adultery with her already in his heart.” Adultery begins with the look. Christ is not satisfied with outward behavior; He demands inward purity, because sin is born in the heart before it appears in the deed. Then He taught about swift reconciliation: if you remember that your brother has something against you while you offer your gift, “leave there thy gift before the altar, and go thy way; first be reconciled to thy brother.” God does not accept your worship while your heart is full of quarreling.

And He closed the chapter with the summit of Christian love: “Ye have heard that it hath been said, Thou shalt love thy neighbour, and hate thine enemy. But I say unto you, Love your enemies, bless them that curse you, do good to them that hate you, and pray for them which despitefully use you, and persecute you; That ye may be the children of your Father which is in heaven” (Matt 5:43-45). This is the distinguishing mark of Christianity: love of enemies. Then the highest summit: “Be ye therefore perfect, even as your Father which is in heaven is perfect” (Matt 5:48). Perfection here means maturity in love — to love as God loves, who “maketh his sun to rise on the evil and on the good, and sendeth rain on the just and on the unjust.” Reflect: which beatitude touches your heart most today? And where do you stand as the light of the world — do people see your good works and glorify your Father in heaven? Pray: Lord, make me salt that does not lose its savor and light that does not go

out. Purify my heart from anger and lust, and teach me to love even my enemies. Amen.

Chapter 7

The Sermon on the Mount (2): The Lord's Prayer and the Heavenly Treasure

In the sixth chapter Christ moves from the heart to worship, and warns against the most dangerous disease of religion: hypocrisy. “Take heed that ye do not your alms before men, to be seen of them” (Matt 6:1). Almsgiving, prayer, and fasting are holy works, but they are corrupted when their aim is the praise of men. The hypocrite gives his alms with a “trumpet” before him, prays standing in the streets to be seen by men, and fasts with a gloomy face to appear to fast — “Verily I say unto you, They have their reward.” What a loss! They labored and fasted and prayed, and their only wage was a fleeting look of admiration. But you — “when thou doest alms, let not thy left hand know what thy right hand doeth,” and “enter into thy closet, and when thou hast shut thy door, pray to thy Father which is in secret; and thy Father which seeth in secret shall reward thee openly.” The golden rule: work for God in secret, and He will reward you openly.

Then Christ taught us the greatest prayer in existence: the Lord's Prayer. “Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven. Give us this day our daily bread. And forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors. And lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil” (Matt 6:9-13). Notice the divine order: it begins with God (His name, His kingdom, His will) before you ask anything for yourself. Then you ask only for today's need — “our daily bread” — not stockpiling anxiety for tomorrow. Then you tie God's forgiveness of you to your forgiveness of others: “as we forgive our debtors.” If you do not forgive your brother, you are practically asking God not to forgive you! That is why Christ added at once: “For if ye forgive men their trespasses, your heavenly Father will also forgive you: But if ye forgive not men their trespasses, neither will your Father forgive your trespasses.”

Then Christ turned our eyes to the true treasure: “Lay not up for yourselves treasures upon earth, where moth and rust doth corrupt, and where thieves

break through and steal: But lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven” (Matt 6:19-20). Everything you gather on earth is liable to loss: money evaporates, health withers, possessions are stolen or rust. But what you give to God — alms, love, service, time in prayer — is a deposit that is never lost. “For where your treasure is, there will your heart be also.” Examine your heart: where is your treasure — in the bank account or in the kingdom of God? Then He said: “No man can serve two masters... Ye cannot serve God and mammon.” There is no neutrality here: either God is your master or money is your master. And the cure for anxiety about the future: “Behold the fowls of the air... your heavenly Father feedeth them. Are ye not much better than they?... Take therefore no thought for the morrow.”

And in the seventh chapter, the most misunderstood commandment: “Judge not, that ye be not judged” (Matt 7:1). Christ does not forbid distinguishing right from wrong; He forbids arrogant condemnation — setting yourself up as a judge over your brother while blind to your own sins. “Why beholdest thou the mote that is in thy brother's eye, but considerest not the beam that is in thine own eye?” Then He sealed the whole sermon with the parable of the two houses: “Therefore whosoever heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them, I will liken him unto a wise man, which built his house upon a rock... And every one that heareth these sayings of mine, and doeth them not, shall be likened unto a foolish man, which built his house upon the sand” (Matt 7:24-26). The rains and winds came, and the house on the sand fell with a great fall, while the house on the rock stood firm. The difference is not in hearing — both heard — but in doing. Christianity is not information to be memorized but a life to be lived. “And it came to pass, when Jesus had ended these sayings, the people were astonished at his doctrine: For he taught them as one having authority, and not as the scribes.”

Reflect: is your prayer full of “give me” and short on “hallowed be Thy name”? And do you carry in your heart an unforgiveness toward someone that blocks God's forgiveness from you? Build your house on the rock: hear the Word and do it today, not tomorrow. Pray the Lord's Prayer slowly tonight, pause at each phrase, and ask yourself: am I living it? Pray: Our Father which art in heaven, hallowed be Thy name in my life before my words. Teach me to forgive as You

forgave me, and to lay up treasure in heaven, not on earth. Amen.

Chapter 8

The Miracles of the Kingdom

After Christ taught with authority in the Sermon on the Mount, He came down from the mountain to prove by deed what He had said in word: “When he was come down from the mountain, great multitudes followed him” (Matt 8:1).

Chapters eight and nine are the gallery of the Kingdom's miracles: ten consecutive miracles displaying Christ's authority over sickness, nature, demons, and even death. A miracle in the Gospel is not a show of power; it is a “sign” — a pointer to something greater: that the kingdom of God has come near, and that the King is present among them.

The first miracle: the leper. A man full of leprosy came — a dreadful, contagious disease; its victim was considered unclean and cast out of society — and “worshipped him, saying, Lord, if thou wilt, thou canst make me clean.” And Jesus stretched out His hand and touched him! Imagine: for years no one had touched him; people fled from him — and Christ stretches out His hand and touches him, saying: “I will; be thou clean” (Matt 8:3). The touch came before the healing: Christ did not only heal his body; He healed his broken heart with touch and acceptance. This is how Christ deals with you in your sin: He does not despise your spiritual leprosy; He touches you and cleanses you. Then came the Roman centurion — a pagan occupier — asking for the healing of his servant, and spoke the immortal words: “Lord, I am not worthy that thou shouldest come under my roof: but speak the word only, and my servant shall be healed.” And Jesus marveled and said: “I have not found so great faith, no, not in Israel!” The faith of the Gentile pagan surpassed the faith of God's people! It is a warning to us: do not rely on being Christian in name, for God looks at the faith of the heart.

Then His authority over nature: “he arose, and rebuked the winds and the sea; and there was a great calm” (Matt 8:26). The disciples — some of them expert fishermen — cried out in the storm: “Lord, save us: we perish!” But He was asleep in the ship! O the peace of the King! With one word He silenced the storm, and they marveled: “What manner of man is this, that even the winds

and the sea obey him!" If He commands nature and it obeys Him, can He not command the storms of your life? Then His authority over demons in the country of the Gergesenes, where He cast a legion out of two men, and the demons entered the herd of swine. And His authority over sin itself: when they brought Him a paralytic, He said to him first, before the bodily healing: "Son, be of good cheer; thy sins be forgiven thee." The scribes grumbled in their hearts: who can forgive sins but God? So He proved His authority to them: "That ye may know that the Son of man hath power on earth to forgive sins, (then saith he to the sick of the palsy,) Arise, take up thy bed, and go unto thine house." And he arose and walked! Forgiveness first, then healing — for the sickness of the soul is more dangerous than the sickness of the body.

And the two most beautiful scenes in the ninth chapter: Jairus the ruler of the synagogue, who came about his dead daughter — and on the way, a woman with an issue of blood for twelve years touched the hem of His garment, "For she said within herself, If I may but touch his garment, I shall be whole." And Jesus turned and said: "Daughter, be of good comfort; thy faith hath made thee whole" (Matt 9:22). Twelve years of bleeding, poverty, and ritual uncleanness — ended by a touch of faith! Then He entered the house of Jairus, took the girl by the hand, and said: "Maid, arise!" — and she arose. Christ is not afraid of death or of uncleanness; He touches the dead and they rise, and the bleeding woman touches Him and is cleansed. He alone turns death into life and uncleanness into purity.

And among the loveliest miracles of this section is the healing of the two blind men: "And when Jesus departed thence, two blind men followed him, crying, and saying, Thou Son of David, have mercy on us" (Matt 9:27). They called Him by His messianic title, "Son of David" — O promised King — though they had never seen Him with their eyes; they saw Him with their hearts better than those who could see! Jesus asked them: "Believe ye that I am able to do this?" They said: Yea, Lord. "Then touched he their eyes, saying, According to your faith be it unto you. And their eyes were opened." Notice the condition: according to your faith. Christ is able to do all things, but He waits for your faith. Many pray without real faith and then wonder why nothing happens. Come to Him today, crying like the two blind men: have mercy on me, Son of

David — and trust that He is able.

Reflect: what “leprosy” are you hiding from people today? Christ is ready to touch it and cleanse it if you come to Him as the leper came: worshipping and saying “if Thou wilt, Thou canst.” And what storm is shaking the ship of your life? The One who slept in the ship was not careless but confident in His Father's authority — trust you too. Pray: Lord, if Thou wilt, Thou canst make me clean. Touch my heart with Your hand, and speak one word, and all my weakness shall be healed. Amen.

Chapter 9

The Sending of the Twelve

After Jesus went about the cities and villages, “moved with compassion” toward the multitudes because “they fainted, and were scattered abroad, as sheep having no shepherd” (Matt 9:36), He said to His disciples: “The harvest truly is plenteous, but the labourers are few; Pray ye therefore the Lord of the harvest, that he will send forth labourers into his harvest.” Then He did something amazing: He answered the very prayer He had asked for! “And when he had called unto him his twelve disciples, he gave them power against unclean spirits, to cast them out, and to heal all manner of sickness and all manner of disease” (Matt 10:1). The harvest is plenteous — and the laborers are you. God does not send angels for the harvest but ordinary people: fishermen and a tax collector. If you feel unqualified for service, you are exactly the kind of people Christ chooses.

And Christ defined their mission precisely: “Go not into the way of the Gentiles, and into any city of the Samaritans enter ye not: But go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.” This was the first stage: begin with the Jews; after the Resurrection the call would widen to all nations. And the message: “Heal the sick, cleanse the lepers, raise the dead, cast out devils: freely ye have received, freely give” (Matt 10:8). Christian service is not a trade: what you received freely from God's grace, give freely. Then He taught them complete dependence: “Provide neither gold, nor silver, nor brass in your purses, Nor scrip for your journey.” The servant does not depend on his bank balance but on his Master; the God who sent him is the God who provides for him. And this is a lesson for every servant today: do not make lack of resources an excuse for not serving, for God provides for His servants.

Then came the hardest part: the cost of discipleship. Christ did not deceive them with rosy promises but spoke plainly: “Behold, I send you forth as sheep in the midst of wolves: be ye therefore wise as serpents, and harmless as doves” (Matt 10:16). They would be delivered to councils, scourged, and hated by all men for His name's sake. “The disciple is not above his master... If they

have called the master of the house Beelzebub, how much more shall they call them of his household!" But amid these hard words, Christ planted the greatest encouragements: "Fear them not therefore... but rather fear him which is able to destroy both soul and body in hell." And: "Are not two sparrows sold for a farthing? and one of them shall not fall on the ground without your Father. But the very hairs of your head are all numbered. Fear ye not therefore, ye are of more value than many sparrows" (Matt 10:29-31). If God cares for the sparrows, will He not care for you, for whom Christ died?

Then words that shake the heart: "Whosoever therefore shall confess me before men, him will I confess also before my Father which is in heaven. But whosoever shall deny me before men, him will I also deny before my Father which is in heaven" (Matt 10:32-33). Confessing Christ openly is not an optional extra for heroes; it is the nature of true faith. Then the hard word: "He that loveth father or mother more than me is not worthy of me: and he that loveth son or daughter more than me is not worthy of me. And he that taketh not his cross, and followeth after me, is not worthy of me. He that findeth his life shall lose it: and he that loseth his life for my sake shall find it" (Matt 10:37-39). Christ demands absolute priority: above family, above self, above life itself. But He closes with the beautiful promise: "He that receiveth you receiveth me, and he that receiveth me receiveth him that sent me... And whosoever shall give to drink unto one of these little ones a cup of cold water only in the name of a disciple, verily I say unto you, he shall in no wise lose his reward." Even a cup of water is counted with God!

Reflect: Christ sends you too today — in your home, at your work, at your university — to be a laborer in His harvest. Do you pray "send laborers" while sitting in your place? Perhaps you are the answer to your own prayer! Do not fear the wolves: He who numbered the hairs of your head will not forsake you. And start small: a cup of cold water in Christ's name shall in no wise lose its reward. Pray: O Lord of the harvest, here am I. Send me where You will, grant me the courage to confess You before men, and make me wise as a serpent and harmless as a dove. Amen.

Chapter 10

The Parables of the Kingdom

In the thirteenth chapter Jesus sat by the sea, and great multitudes gathered to Him, “so that he went into a ship, and sat; and the whole multitude stood on the shore” (Matt 13:2). And from there He began to speak in parables. The disciples asked Him: “Why speakest thou unto them in parables?” And He answered with words that sound strange: “Because it is given unto you to know the mysteries of the kingdom of heaven, but to them it is not given.” Does Christ deliberately hide the truth? No — rather, the parable reveals to the humble, seeking heart, and hides from the proud, resisting heart. The same sun melts wax and hardens clay; the same parable enlightens the disciple and blinds the Pharisee. Whoever seeks sincerely understands; whoever listens mockingly hears and does not understand. That is why Isaiah the prophet said of such: “By hearing ye shall hear, and shall not understand.”

The first and most important of the parables: the parable of the sower.

“Behold, a sower went forth to sow; And when he sowed, some seeds fell by the way side... some fell upon stony places... some fell among thorns... But other fell into good ground, and brought forth fruit” (Matt 13:3-8). And Christ explained it Himself: the seed is the word of the Kingdom, and the soil is the heart. The wayside: a hard heart trampled by the feet of habits, so the wicked one comes and snatches the word. The stony places: an emotional heart that receives the word with joy but has no roots, so when tribulation comes it falls away at once. The thorns: a heart crowded with the cares of the world and the deceitfulness of riches, choking the word. But the good ground is “he that heareth the word, and understandeth it” — bringing forth fruit, thirty, sixty, and a hundredfold. Ask yourself honestly: which soil am I? And the good news: soil can be plowed! The hard heart can be softened by repentance and prayer.

Then the parable of the wheat and the tares: a man sowed good seed in his field, but “while men slept, his enemy came and sowed tares among the wheat, and went his way.” The servants said: shall we gather the tares? He answered: “Nay; lest while ye gather up the tares, ye root up also the wheat with them.

Let both grow together until the harvest” (Matt 13:29-30). This parable answers a question that perplexes many: why does God allow the wicked to exist in the Church and in the world? The answer: because early uprooting might harm the wheat, and because God in His longsuffering gives the tares a chance to become wheat through repentance. But do not think God is unaware: “in the time of harvest I will say to the reapers, Gather ye together first the tares, and bind them in bundles to burn them: but gather the wheat into my barn.” Judgment is surely coming — so make sure you are wheat.

Then parables small in size but great in meaning: “The kingdom of heaven is like to a grain of mustard seed, which a man took, and sowed in his field: Which indeed is the least of all seeds: but when it is grown, it is the greatest among herbs, and becometh a tree, so that the birds of the air come and lodge in the branches thereof” (Matt 13:31-32). The Kingdom began with twelve simple men — and today it embraces hundreds of millions in every nation! Do not despise small beginnings in your spiritual life: a short prayer, a single verse, a small service — they may become a great tree. And the parable of the treasure hidden in the field and the pearl of great price: a man found a treasure and “for joy thereof goeth and selleth all that he hath, and buyeth that field.” The Kingdom is worth selling everything for — not grudgingly but “for joy”! Whoever has truly found Christ does not grieve over what he left but rejoices over what he found.

And Christ closed His parables with the parable of the net: “Again, the kingdom of heaven is like unto a net, that was cast into the sea, and gathered of every kind: Which, when it was full, they drew to shore, and sat down, and gathered the good into vessels, but cast the bad away. So shall it be at the end of the world: the angels shall come forth, and sever the wicked from among the just, And shall cast them into the furnace of fire” (Matt 13:47-50). The net now gathers of every kind — the Church holds saints and sinners together — but the sorting is coming at the end. Do not deceive yourself with a merely formal presence in the net; what matters is to be among the “good” gathered into the vessels. And today is the day of voluntary sorting: examine yourself now, before the angels sort you.

Reflect: Christ closed the parables with a question: "Have ye understood all these things?" They said: Yea. And He said: "Therefore every scribe which is instructed unto the kingdom of heaven is like unto a man that is an householder, which bringeth forth out of his treasure things new and old" (Matt 13:52). The wise servant brings from the treasure of the Word both old and new. And you: did your word today fall on good ground? Plow your heart every morning with prayer, water it with the Word, and guard it from the thorns of cares. Pray: Lord, make my heart good ground that hears Your word, understands it, and bears fruit. Uproot every tare from me, and make me wheat gathered into Your barn. Amen.

The Great Confession and the Transfiguration

Jesus arrived with His disciples at the region of Caesarea Philippi, and there He asked them the most dangerous question in existence: “Whom do men say that I the Son of man am?” They answered: some say John the Baptist, others Elijah, others Jeremiah or one of the prophets. Then He turned the question on them personally: “But whom say ye that I am?” (Matt 16:15). Notice that Christ did not ask: what do you know about Me? but: who am I to you? Christianity is not information about Christ but a personal relationship with Him. And the question is addressed to you today as well: who is Jesus to you? A great prophet? A moral teacher? Or more?

And Simon Peter answered with the immortal confession: “Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God” (Matt 16:16). Six words that summed up the whole Christian faith! “The Christ”: the promised King. “The Son of God”: not merely a man, but God Himself. “The living”: not a dead god of the past, but alive and working today. Jesus answered him: “Blessed art thou, Simon Barjona: for flesh and blood hath not revealed it unto thee, but my Father which is in heaven.” True faith is not the product of human intelligence but a divine revelation to the humble heart. Then He spoke to him the great words: “Thou art Peter, and upon this rock I will build my church; and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it” (Matt 16:18). The rock here — according to the faith of our Church — is the rock of the confession itself: faith that Jesus is the Christ, the Son of the living God. Upon this faith the Church is built in every generation, and it is this faith that the gates of hell shall not overcome. Then He gave him “the keys of the kingdom of heaven”: the authority of binding and loosing — declaring God's forgiveness to the repentant — the same authority the Church exercises in the sacrament of repentance and confession to this day.

And after six days Jesus took Peter, James, and John, “and bringeth them up into an high mountain apart, And was transfigured before them: and his face did shine as the sun, and his raiment was white as the light” (Matt 17:1-2). The

Transfiguration! For a moment the divine glory hidden behind the human flesh was unveiled, and the disciples saw Christ as He is in His glory. “And, behold, there appeared unto them Moses and Elias talking with him.” Moses represents the Law, Elijah the prophets — the whole Old Testament came to witness to Christ and to speak with Him of His “decease,” that is, His coming Cross. Peter said, overwhelmed: “Lord, it is good for us to be here: if thou wilt, let us make here three tabernacles.” But the Father interrupted him with a voice from the cloud: “This is my beloved Son, in whom I am well pleased; hear ye him.” The word was no longer Moses' or Elijah's, but Christ's alone: hear Him! “And when the disciples heard it, they fell on their face, and were sore afraid. And Jesus came and touched them, and said, Arise, and be not afraid. And when they had lifted up their eyes, they saw no man, save Jesus only.”

Why the Transfiguration? Because Christ had begun to tell them of His sufferings and His Cross, and they were afraid and troubled. So He showed them His glory in advance, that they might know the Cross is not defeat but the road to glory — and that the One who would be crucified is the same King of glory. And we celebrate this glorious feast in our Church on the 13th of Mesra. And the Transfiguration is not only a memory: the saints teach us that divine grace is able to “transfigure” our lives too, changing us “from glory to glory” into that same image. Every time you pray deeply, or partake worthily, or repent with tears, the light of Christ shines in you a little more.

Reflect: Christ's question is still put to you: “But whom say ye that I am?” Do not answer with what people say, but with what your heart says. And if your confession is sincere like Peter's, you will hear the same blessing: blessed art thou. Then ascend with Him to the mountain every day in prayer, to see His glory and hear the Father's voice: hear Him. Pray: Thou art the Christ, the Son of the living God. I believe, Lord — help my unbelief. Change my form as Your form was changed, and make my face reflect Your light to others. Amen.

Lessons of the Kingdom: Humility and Forgiveness

The eighteenth chapter is the “discourse on the Church”: how the children of the Kingdom live together. And it began with a question revealing an old sickness of the human heart: “At the same time came the disciples unto Jesus, saying, Who is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?” (Matt 18:1). Even the disciples — after all they had seen — were competing for positions! Jesus answered with an unforgettable practical lesson: “And Jesus called a little child unto him, and set him in the midst of them, And said, Verily I say unto you, Except ye be converted, and become as little children, ye shall not enter into the kingdom of heaven. Whosoever therefore shall humble himself as this little child, the same is greatest in the kingdom of heaven” (Matt 18:2-4). The road to greatness in the Kingdom is exactly reversed: not by rising but by descending, not by pride but by humility like children — in their simplicity, their trust, their lack of pretense. Pride is Satan's first sin, and it shuts the door of the Kingdom; but the humble enters through the wide gate.

Then Christ warned with a fearful warning against offending the little ones: “But whoso shall offend one of these little ones which believe in me, it were better for him that a millstone were hanged about his neck, and that he were drowned in the depth of the sea” (Matt 18:6). O how dangerous it is to be a stumbling block to a simple believer — by a careless word, a hypocritical conduct, or a bad example! Then He taught about seeking the lost sheep: the good shepherd “leaveth the ninety and nine in the mountains, and goeth into the mountains, and seeketh that which is gone astray; and if so be that he find it, he rejoiceth more of that sheep, than of the ninety and nine which went not astray.” Such is God's heart: He does not say “I have ninety-nine, one does not matter” — He rejoices greatly over the one who returns. If you are the distant, lost one, know that the Shepherd is seeking you now. And if you are among the ninety-nine, learn from your Shepherd: seek your distant brothers instead of judging them.

Then Christ set a wise order for reconciliation between brothers — the basis of what the Church practices to this day: “Moreover if thy brother shall trespass against thee, go and tell him his fault between thee and him alone: if he shall hear thee, thou hast gained thy brother” (Matt 18:15). Notice the order: first between you and him alone — do not expose him before people, and do not tell everyone before you speak to him! The goal is “thou hast gained thy brother,” not “thou hast won the case.” And if he will not hear, take with you one or two more; and if he persists, tell the Church. How wise this progression! How many quarrels would have ended at the first step, if only we had humbled ourselves and gone and spoken to our brother face to face instead of talking about him to everyone.

Then Peter asked the question we all ask: “Lord, how oft shall my brother sin against me, and I forgive him? till seven times?” Peter was generous in his estimate — the Pharisees said three times was enough! Jesus answered: “I say not unto thee, Until seven times: but, Until seventy times seven” (Matt 18:22). That is, without number, without limit! Then He told the parable of the unforgiving servant: a master forgave his servant an enormous debt — ten thousand talents, an unimaginable sum never to be repaid in a lifetime — “then the lord of that servant was moved with compassion, and loosed him, and forgave him the debt.” But this servant went out and found a fellow servant who owed him a hundred pence — a trifling sum — “and he laid hands on him, and took him by the throat, saying, Pay me that thou owest!” — and cast him into prison! When the other servants saw what was done they were very sorry, and the master was angry and said: “O thou wicked servant, I forgave thee all that debt, because thou desiredst me: Shouldest not thou also have had compassion on thy fellowservant, even as I had pity on thee?” — and delivered him to the tormentors. And Christ closed: “So likewise shall my heavenly Father do also unto you, if ye from your hearts forgive not every one his brother their trespasses.” Our debt to God is beyond counting; our brother's debt to us is trifling beside it. Whoever has tasted true forgiveness cannot but forgive.

Reflect: is there someone in your life you have not forgiven yet? Remember that every time you pray “forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors,” you

are signing this condition. Forgiveness does not mean the wound never happened; it means you leave judgment to God and release your heart from the prison of bitterness. Begin today: pray for the one who wronged you, and go and be reconciled to your brother. Pray: Lord, You forgave me so much — how can I not forgive so little? Remove all bitterness from my heart, make me humble as the children, and merciful as You were merciful to me. Amen.

Chapter 13

The Royal Entry into Jerusalem

After three years of teaching and miracles, the decisive moment came: Jesus went up to Jerusalem for the last time. Before entering, He sent two of His disciples, saying: “Go into the village over against you, and straightway ye shall find an ass tied, and a colt with her: loose them, and bring them unto me” (Matt 21:2). Jesus rode the colt and entered Jerusalem, “And a very great multitude spread their garments in the way; others cut down branches from the trees, and strawed them in the way. And the multitudes that went before, and that followed, cried, saying, Hosanna to the Son of David: Blessed is he that cometh in the name of the Lord; Hosanna in the highest” (Matt 21:8-9). This is Palm Sunday, which we celebrate every year in our Church with palm fronds and olive branches.

But notice the astonishing paradox: a king entering his capital riding a donkey's colt! Earthly kings enter on war horses and gilded chariots, but the King of the Kingdom enters meekly on a colt, the foal of an ass — exactly as Zechariah prophesied five hundred years before: “Rejoice greatly, O daughter of Zion... behold, thy King cometh unto thee: he is just, and having salvation; lowly, and riding upon an ass, and upon a colt the foal of an ass” (Matt 21:5). The colt symbolizes meekness and peace: this King did not come to conquer with the sword but to reign by love. And the crowds understood something of this, crying “Hosanna” — that is, “save now” — and “Son of David,” the awaited messianic King. But many of them were expecting an earthly king to drive out the Romans — and within days, when they saw their King rejected and crucified, their cry would turn from “Hosanna” to “Crucify Him”! A terrifying lesson: emotional enthusiasm without a true understanding of Christ quickly turns into hostility.

And Jesus entered the temple directly, and saw what angered Him: “And Jesus went into the temple of God, and cast out all them that sold and bought in the temple, and overthrew the tables of the moneychangers, and the seats of them that sold doves, And said unto them, It is written, My house shall be called the

house of prayer; but ye have made it a den of thieves" (Matt 21:12-13). The merchants occupied the court of the Gentiles — the only place where Gentiles were allowed to pray — and exploited the pilgrims with unjust prices. Zeal for God's house consumed the meek Christ, and He became a lion! Then "the blind and the lame came to him in the temple; and he healed them." Notice the divine order: first He cleansed the temple of commerce, then He opened it to the sick and the broken. God's house is for prayer and healing, not for trade and interests. And ask yourself: is the temple of your heart a house of prayer, or has it become a marketplace busy with the cares of the world? Christ wants to cleanse it today as He cleansed the temple.

And in the following days in Jerusalem, Christ confronted the chief priests with powerful parables exposing their rejection of Him: the parable of the two sons (one said he would go and did not go — like the Pharisees who say and do not do), and the parable of the wicked husbandmen who killed the owner's servants and then killed his son — so Christ said: "The kingdom of God shall be taken from you, and given to a nation bringing forth the fruits thereof" (Matt 21:43). Fearful words: religious privilege does not protect from judgment if it bears no fruit. Then the parable of the marriage of the king's son: the king invited the guests, but they refused with trifling excuses — "one to his farm, another to his merchandise" — so the angry king sent his servants into the highways and gathered all they found. The invitation is open to all — but whoever refuses it on the excuse of busyness loses the wedding. And you are invited today: will you accept the invitation, or excuse yourself with farm and merchandise?

Reflect: on Palm Sunday we cry with the children "Hosanna" — but the question is: do we accept Christ as King over our lives on His terms, not ours? The crowds wanted a king who would fulfill their political dreams; when a King came demanding repentance and the Cross, they rejected Him. Do not make Jesus a king after your own desire: a king of blessings only, without obedience. Open the doors of your heart to Him today as Jerusalem opened its gates, and let Him cleanse the temple of your life from every strange commerce. Pray: O my meek King, enter the Jerusalem of my heart, riding on Your humility. Cleanse me from all that is unworthy of Your house, and make

my cry to You true all the days of my life, not on Palm Sunday only. Amen.

The Discourse on the Mount of Olives

Jesus went out of the temple, and His disciples showed Him the temple's magnificent buildings with pride — and He spoke words that terrified them: “Verily I say unto you, There shall not be left here one stone upon another, that shall not be thrown down” (Matt 24:2). The temple, which Herod had built with indescribable splendor, would be utterly destroyed — and it truly happened in the year 70 AD at the hands of the Romans. So the disciples asked Him on the Mount of Olives: “Tell us, when shall these things be? and what shall be the sign of thy coming, and of the end of the world?” And He answered them with the fifth and final discourse: the eschatological discourse. Its aim is not to satisfy curiosity about dates but one thing: constant readiness.

Christ first warned them against deception: “Take heed that no man deceive you. For many shall come in my name, saying, I am Christ; and shall deceive many” (Matt 24:4-5). Then He described the signs of the times: wars and rumors of wars, famines, pestilences, and earthquakes — “but all these are the beginning of sorrows.” Then persecution: “Then shall they deliver you up to be afflicted, and shall kill you: and ye shall be hated of all nations for my name's sake.” Then the cooling of love: “And because iniquity shall abound, the love of many shall wax cold. But he that shall endure unto the end, the same shall be saved” (Matt 24:13). This verse is the summary of the whole discourse: enduring to the end is the condition. What matters is not to begin well but to end well. How many began the spiritual life with zeal, then their love grew cold because of the abounding iniquity around them! Hold fast to Christ every day — for he that endures to the end shall be saved.

But as for the time of His coming, He said with decisive clarity: “But of that day and hour knoweth no man, no, not the angels of heaven, but my Father only” (Matt 24:36). Everyone who sets a date for Christ's coming — and many have done so through history — is a liar or deceived, for Christ Himself said that the Father alone knows. Therefore the commandment is not “calculate the date” but “watch”: “Watch therefore: for ye know not what hour your Lord

doth come.” The coming will be “as the lightning” and “as the days of Noah”: people were eating and drinking and marrying “until the day that Noe entered into the ark, And knew not until the flood came, and took them all away.” Life will go on perfectly normally — then suddenly the Lord comes. The question is not “when?” but “am I ready?”

Then He told three parables about readiness: the faithful servant whom his lord made ruler over his household to give them meat in due season — blessed is he if his lord finds him doing so when he comes. And the ten virgins: five wise who took oil in their vessels with their lamps, and five foolish who took lamps without oil. “While the bridegroom tarried, they all slumbered and slept. And at midnight there was a cry made, Behold, the bridegroom cometh; go ye out to meet him!” The foolish went to buy oil, and “while they went to buy, the bridegroom came; and they that were ready went in with him to the marriage: and the door was shut.” They cried: Lord, open to us! And He answered: “Verily I say unto you, I know you not.” O the terror! The oil is grace and the inward spiritual life — it cannot be borrowed or bought at the last moment. Your family's faith will not avail you, nor the prayers of others for you; you must have your own oil.

And the parable of the talents: a master gave his servants talents — five, two, and one — “to every man according to his several ability,” and traveled. The first and second traded and gained; but the third hid his talent in the earth. When the master returned he praised the faithful: “Well done, thou good and faithful servant: thou hast been faithful over a few things, I will make thee ruler over many things: enter thou into the joy of thy lord.” But the slothful one had his talent taken and was cast out. God gave you talents: time, gifts, health, money — what have you done with them? Then the final judgment scene: “When the Son of man shall come in his glory... shall be gathered all nations before him” — and He shall separate them as a shepherd divides the sheep from the goats. And the standard is surprising: “For I was an hungred, and ye gave me meat: I was thirsty, and ye gave me drink: I was a stranger, and ye took me in: Naked, and ye clothed me: I was sick, and ye visited me: I was in prison, and ye came unto me.” “Inasmuch as ye have done it unto one of the least of these my brethren, ye have done it unto me.” Judgment is not on

memorized doctrines but on lived love. Reflect: is your lamp filled with oil today? And what have you done with your talents? Pray: Lord, make me a faithful, watchful servant; fill my lamp with the oil of Your grace; and teach me to see You in every hungry, thirsty, and stranger. Amen.

Chapter 15

The Passion and the Crucifixion

We now approach the holiest and hardest chapters of the Gospel: the sufferings and death of Christ. Read this chapter with a reverent heart, for every word here cost blood. It all began in Bethany, when a woman poured a flask of very precious ointment on Jesus' head. The disciples were indignant: what waste! It could have been sold for three hundred pence and given to the poor! But Jesus defended her: "Why trouble ye the woman? for she hath wrought a good work upon me... For in that she hath poured this ointment on my body, she did it for my burial. Verily I say unto you, Wheresoever this gospel shall be preached in the whole world, there shall also this, that this woman hath done, be told for a memorial of her" (Matt 26:10-13). True love for Christ does not count the cost. Mary gave the costliest, and gained immortality. But Judas Iscariot went to the chief priests and bargained with them: "What will ye give me, and I will deliver him unto you? And they covenanted with him for thirty pieces of silver" (Matt 26:15). The price of a slave! He sold his Master cheaply. Beware: betrayal begins small — the love of money in Judas's heart grew until it swallowed everything.

Then the Last Supper: and as they were eating, "Jesus took bread, and blessed it, and brake it, and gave it to the disciples, and said, Take, eat; this is my body. And he took the cup, and gave thanks, and gave it to them, saying, Drink ye all of it; For this is my blood of the new testament, which is shed for many for the remission of sins" (Matt 26:26-28). On this night Christ instituted the sacrament of the Eucharist, which we celebrate in every liturgy to this day: the bread and the wine become His true Body and Blood for the remission of sins and eternal life. Then they went out to the Mount of Olives, to the garden of Gethsemane. And there the inward sufferings began: "he began to be sorrowful and very heavy. Then saith he unto them, My soul is exceeding sorrowful, even unto death." And He fell on His face and prayed: "O my Father, if it be possible, let this cup pass from me: nevertheless not as I will, but as thou wilt" (Matt 26:39). Three times He prayed thus, and His sweat

became as drops of blood. Christ was not acting out suffering; as perfect man He felt the real fear of death and of the curse He would bear. But He obeyed: "thy will be done." And in His obedience is our salvation.

Then Judas came with an armed crowd, and kissed his Master with the kiss of betrayal. Jesus said to him the heart-melting word: "Friend, wherefore art thou come?" (Matt 26:50). Even in the moment of His arrest He called him "friend"! Jesus was seized and dragged to unjust trials by night: before Annas and Caiaphas, then the council. "Now the chief priests, and elders, and all the council, sought false witness against Jesus, to put him to death; But found none" (Matt 26:59-60). Finally the high priest asked Him: "I adjure thee by the living God, that thou tell us whether thou be the Christ, the Son of God." Jesus said: "Thou hast said: nevertheless I say unto you, Hereafter shall ye see the Son of man sitting on the right hand of power, and coming in the clouds of heaven." Then the high priest tore his clothes, crying: He has blasphemed! And they condemned Him to death. They spat in His face and struck Him. And outside, Peter was denying Him: "I know not the man!" — three times — then the cock crowed, and "he went out, and wept bitterly." The difference between Judas and Peter: both fell, but Peter wept and repented and was restored, while Judas despaired and hanged himself. However far you have fallen, do not despair like Judas; weep like Peter and return.

And Jesus was delivered to Pontius Pilate the Roman governor, who found Him innocent and tried to release Him — but the crowds cried: "Crucify Him! Crucify Him!" So Pilate washed his hands — but washing hands does not wash the conscience. They scourged Jesus, plaited a crown of thorns and put it on His head, mocked Him, then led Him to Golgotha and crucified Him between two thieves, writing His accusation: "This is Jesus the King of the Jews." And from the sixth hour to the ninth "there was darkness over all the land" — then Jesus cried: "My God, my God, why hast thou forsaken me?" — the moment He bore the sins of the world and the Father's face was hidden from Him. Then He cried with a loud voice and yielded up the ghost. "And, behold, the veil of the temple was rent in twain from the top to the bottom; and the earth did quake, and the rocks rent" (Matt 27:51). The tearing of the veil means: the way into the Holy of Holies — into God's presence — was opened to all by the

blood of Christ! Then Joseph of Arimathea took the body, wrapped it, and buried it in a new tomb. Was it all over? No — the story had not ended.

Reflect: stand before the Cross and ask: why? The answer: for me. “He was wounded for our transgressions, he was bruised for our iniquities.” Do not pass by Christ's sufferings casually in Holy Week; stand, look, weep, and give thanks. And if you have fallen into sin, remember Peter: bitter weeping and sincere repentance will restore you. Pray: O Thou who suffered for me, how can I thank You? Accept my tears as You accepted the woman's ointment; wash me with Your blood from every sin; and make Your Cross my pride and my strength. Amen.

Chapter 16

The Resurrection and the Great Commission

“In the end of the sabbath, as it began to dawn toward the first day of the week, came Mary Magdalene and the other Mary to see the sepulchre. And, behold, there was a great earthquake: for the angel of the Lord descended from heaven, and came and rolled back the stone from the door, and sat upon it” (Matt 28:1-2). O the sight! The Roman guards became “as dead men” from fear — but the two faithful women who came at dawn to honor the Dead were the first to hear the greatest news in history: “Fear not ye: for I know that ye seek Jesus, which was crucified. He is not here: for he is risen, as he said!” (Matt 28:5-6). “He is not here: for he is risen” — words that shook the world and changed history. The empty tomb is the heart of the Christian faith; without the Resurrection the Cross would have been mere tragedy, and Christianity a sad philosophy. But He is risen! Death is defeated, sin is broken, Satan is crushed.

And the angel said to them: “Come, see the place where the Lord lay. And go quickly, and tell his disciples that he is risen from the dead; and, behold, he goeth before you into Galilee; there shall ye see him.” Notice: the first ones sent to preach the Resurrection were two women! In a society that did not accept a woman's testimony, God chose the two women to be the first preachers. Christ honors the faithful and simple. “And they departed quickly from the sepulchre with fear and great joy; and did run to bring his disciples word. And as they went to tell his disciples, behold, Jesus met them, saying, All hail. And they came and held him by the feet, and worshipped him” (Matt 28:8-9). The first appearance of the risen Lord was to these two loving women. Whoever seeks Jesus early — as they did at dawn — finds Him. And whoever loves Him with all his heart hears His voice saying: all hail.

But the chief priests, when they heard the news from the guards, did not repent; they bribed them with large money and said: “Say ye, His disciples came by night, and stole him away while we slept.” What nonsense! How could the disciples steal the body while the guards slept? And how could they see

them stealing it while asleep? The lie is exposed — yet it spread “among the Jews until this day,” as Matthew says. This is what man does when he rejects the truth: he invents a lie and pays the price of spreading it. But the truth cannot be buried: Christ is risen, He appeared to His disciples and to more than five hundred brethren at once, and nothing can explain the transformation of the cowardly disciples into courageous martyrs except a real Resurrection they saw with their own eyes.

Then the closing scene on the mountain in Galilee: “Then the eleven disciples went away into Galilee, into a mountain where Jesus had appointed them. And when they saw him, they worshipped him: but some doubted” (Matt 28:16-17). Amazing: even after the Resurrection “some doubted”! Christ did not rebuke them for their doubt; He came to them and spoke the words that changed the world — the Great Commission: “All power is given unto me in heaven and in earth. Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you always, even unto the end of the world” (Matt 28:18-20). All power is His — therefore do not fear. Go — the Gospel is not for sitting but for going. Teach all nations — salvation is for the whole world, not for the Jews only. Baptize them and teach them — discipleship is baptism, teaching, and keeping the commandments, not a mere emotional decision.

And consider the ending: “and, lo, I am with you always, even unto the end of the world.” The Gospel that began with “Emmanuel — God with us” ends with “I am with you always.” From Nativity to Resurrection, the message is one: God is with us! You are never alone: in your joy and your sorrow, in your strength and your weakness, in your service and your failure — He is with you always. With these words the eleven disciples set out — simple men with no money and no weapons — and turned the world upside down. And today the call is addressed to you: go and make disciples. You may not go to the ends of the earth, but go to your home, your neighbors, your colleagues. Tell them of Him who rose from the dead. Pray: O risen Lord, fill my heart with the joy of the Resurrection. Behold, I accept Your commission: I will tell those around me that You are alive, and I will trust that You are with me always, even unto the

end of the world. Amen.

Conclusion

Here we have reached the end of our journey with the Gospel of Matthew — yet it is truly a beginning, not an end. We walked with the tax collector who became an evangelist; we saw the royal genealogy and the wondrous Nativity; we followed the star with the Magi to the manger; we heard the Father's voice at the Jordan; we stood with Christ in His temptations and victories; we sat on the mountain hearing the constitution of the Kingdom; we saw His hand heal the leper and raise the dead; we heard Him send His disciples and teach them humility and forgiveness; we entered Jerusalem with Him amid the hosannas; we watched with Him in Gethsemane; we stood beneath His Cross; then we ran with the two Marys to the empty tomb and heard: He is risen! And now we hear His final voice: go... and I am with you always.

What is the golden thread that ties the whole Gospel together? It is “God with us.” It began with Emmanuel at the Nativity and ended with “I am with you” in the Commission. Between beginning and end, we saw a meek King unlike all the kings of the earth: born in a manger, fleeing as a refugee, tempted and hungering, weeping and sorrowing, dying crucified — then rising! This is our King: near to the brokenhearted, a friend of sinners, the shepherd of lost sheep. If you have known Christ before, may you have known Him more deeply today. And if this is the first time you have truly drawn near to Him, know that He has been waiting for you since eternity.

And now a final invitation: do not place this book on the shelf and forget it. Take the Gospel of Matthew itself and read it all, from beginning to end — only twenty-eight chapters; you can read them in two weeks at two chapters a day. Read it with an open heart and a simple prayer before each reading: Lord, open my eyes. And you will discover that the Word is living and powerful, and that the Christ you read about will speak to you personally. And when you finish Matthew, move on to Mark, Luke, and John, then to the rest of the New Testament. The whole Bible is a treasure that never runs out.

And let the motto of your life from this Gospel be two words Christ spoke: “Follow me” at the beginning, and “I am with you” at the end. Between the call and the promise, live discipleship day by day: continual repentance, heartfelt

prayer, boundless forgiveness, love even for enemies, sacrificial service, and watchful readiness to meet the Bridegroom. And may the Lord bless you and keep you; may the Lord make His face shine upon you and be gracious to you; may the Lord lift up His countenance upon you and give you peace, now and forever. Amen.